

The Great fire-wall of China

In an effort to let local propaganda trickle through to the Chinese people, the US. government's Voice of America broadcasts has commissioned creation of software that will let people circumvent the firewalls thrown up by the Chinese government. The software enables PC users running Microsoft's Windows XP or 2000 operating systems to tunnel through firewalls.

The idea behind the software is to allow evasion of firewalls through a third-party computer. The software, which uses Secure Sockets Layer (SSL), lets the person who installs it, set up a miniature Web site through which a firewall-restricted surfer can access the rest of the Web.

In addition to circumventing firewalls, the software also creates anonymity by covering the Web surfer's tracks and leaving no record of what sites he or she visited beyond the miniature Web site.

However, such software can also be used by under-aged kids and other sections of society to gain access to information that is otherwise restricted.

snapshot

By **2008**, the market for mobile adult-oriented services may add up to **\$1 billion**

Source: NTT-DoCoMo/Strategy Analytics

Yepp, it's cool

Samsung Electronics expects its new MP3 player—the Yepp YP-55—to grab the domestic Korean youth market. The new products are available with either 128 MB or 256 MB built in onboard memory. Though very small, they feature SRS Lab's WOW, MP3 encoding, FM radio and sound recording capability. In a strategic tie-up with SRS, this is the first flash memory MP3 player that supports WOW, which offers greatly enhanced bass tones and 3D sound. SRS Lab's WOW surround sound simulator, processes stereo channels to give the sound a more immersive, 3D feel.

The direct MP3 encoding



allows music from various sources—CD players, cassette tape players or FM radio—to be directly stored as MP3 files, without having

to connect the MP3

player with a personal computer. The player can operate on a single AAA battery for up to 15 hours; the FM radio can select 20 different channels, and an auto-search function is included. The YP-55 is expected to retail for \$ 172 for the 128 MB version and \$ 205 for the 256 MB version.

The Korean market for flash MP3 players is estimated to be around 400,000 units in 2003, and Samsung Electronics expects to grab at least a 50 per cent market share.

A star is born

The infamous Iraqi information minister, Muhammed Saeed al-Sahaf has carved a niche in the hearts of many an Internet surfer. A Web site called We Love the Iraqi Information Minister, has become an Internet phenomenon. One-liners uttered by al-Sahhaf, such as “My feelings—as usual—we will slaughter them all”, “I speak better English than this villain Bush”, and delectable spins such as “The authority of the civil defence, issued a warning to the civilian popu-

lation not to pick up any of those pencils because they are booby traps, ...they have started throwing those pencils, but they are not pencils, they are

booby traps to kill the children”, have guaranteed a place in history for the Minister. Within one hour of the launch of the Web site, it was getting

1,000 visits per second (www.welovetheiraqiminister.com). This number grew to 4,000 per second within days of the launch, forcing the team to move to a bigger server to cope with the traffic.



Iraqi information minister

Muhammed Saeed al-Sahaf



heroes

BSNL

The Kolkata telephone service system—Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited (BSNL)—has just started an ‘Always On’ Internet access system through their extensive phone network. Christened as the Direct Internet Access Service (DIAS), this service offers a 128 Kbps connection at relatively affordable rates.

Online Banking Customers

Customers have never had it so good, with banks offering sops when customers choose to pay their bills online, instead of writing checks. Customers who choose to clear bills through the Internet stand to win massive rebates and bonuses such as entering the sweepstakes to win sports utility vehicles.



zeroes

P2P

In a further clampdown of P2P networks on university campuses across the U.S, the RIAA has just filed lawsuits against four university students for setting up P2P networks across three college campuses. The RIAA is pressing for damages that could come to \$150,000 per infringed song. Since late last year, the RIAA has been targeting university based file swapping networks in an effort to curb copyright violations.

SONICblue

Faced with bankruptcy after the agreement with Japan's D&M Holdings fell through, SONICblue, the maker of acclaimed products such as the ReplayTV and Rio MP3 players is now going to be auctioned off by a bankruptcy court.

■ 12 Taiwanese companies pool silicon know-how to boost the country's chip competitiveness